

Black mask (traditionally, Harlequin had a blacked face)

Harlequin Probably the best-known *commedia dell'arte* character, even today, Harlequin is witty, mischievous, clownish, childlike, and nimble. Early Harlequin costumes were sewn together from patches, which was probably the origin of the diamond motif.



Belt over front-fastened jacket

Distinctive suit patterned with coloured diamonds

Soft, slipper-like shoes



Mask with long, crooked nose

Pot belly

Sugarloaf hat (named after the large cones in which sugar was sold)

Floppy white neck ruffle

Pulcinella Cantankerous rather than clown-like, the Pulcinella character is dwarfish and humpbacked. In Italian his name means "little chicken". In English he became Mr Punch in traditional Punch and Judy shows.

1710



High hairstyle threaded with ribbon and feathers

Gold mask

Short train and skirt folded back at sides

Mantua-style dress has separate bodice and petticoat

Deep border of silver fabric at hem

Fancy-dress attributes A character could be established by adding relevant touches to a stylish dress – for instance, a silver gown or crescent-shaped jewellery would suggest Diana, Roman goddess of the moon and the hunt.

1790



Shako (tall military hat)

Short cape worn over one shoulder

Gold braiding on jacket

Short jacket called a dolman

Trousers were usually red

High leather riding boots

Hussar Dashing Hungarian soldiers (Hussars) rode fast horses, acted as scouts, and took on dangerous skirmishes. Their youth and courage fired public imagination, and their glamorous uniforms were ideal for costume balls.

LADY WITH A MASK



This print of a portrait by British artist Henry Morland is called *The Fair Nun Unmasked*. In 18th-century England the word "nun" could suggest a prostitute, and the painting is a form of satire. The black veil suits this purpose, since whores of the time often donned religious dress. The veil also suggests an Italian *batua*, a length of black silk that covered the face for masquerades.